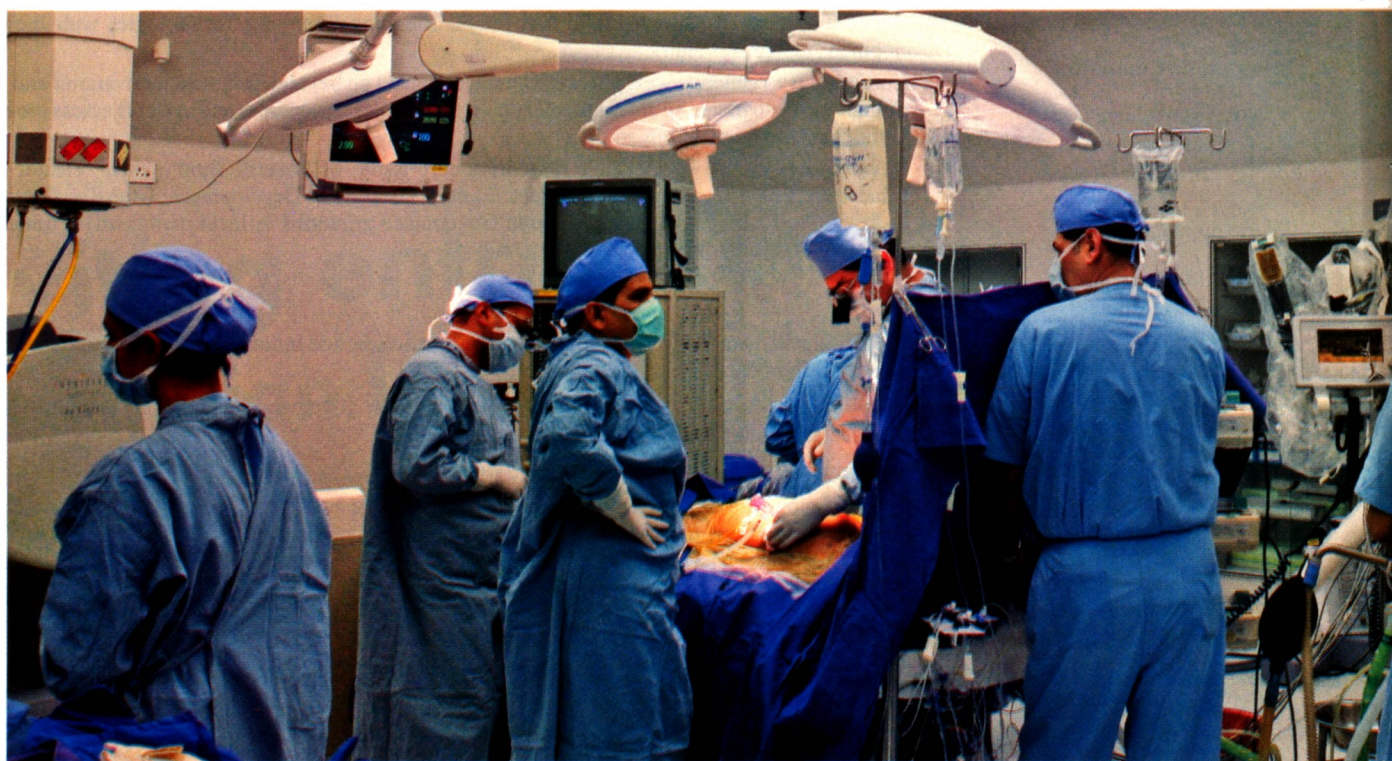


A CONVERGENCE of public and private interests is a must to combat the inevitable onslaught of lifestyle diseases



Affluence Ails

BY 2015, THE PREVALENCE OF DIABETES IS LIKELY TO GROW FROM 2.8 PER CENT OF THE POPULATION IN 2005 TO 3.7 PER CENT; CORONARY HEART DISEASE FROM 3.3 TO 4.9 PER CENT; AND OBESITY FROM 1.3 TO 2.7 PER CENT.

The health of a nation's population is vital for its economic development, prosperity and internal stability. In India, investments to build the country's social fabric, in particular, healthcare and education are especially critical, as India is projected to become the world's most populous country by 2035. It is already the youngest: It is home to 20 per cent of the world's population under 24 years of age.

Such a large young population could provide the nation with a huge competitive advantage, but it also brings with it the burden of providing basic necessities as education, healthcare, employment and clean living con-

ditions. Though India has done well in some of these areas—notably, in economic development—it needs to do a great deal more in healthcare and education. India's health indicators are lagging, when compared with those of other developing countries like China, Indonesia and Sri Lanka. The country continues to struggle to achieve the positive health outcomes that citizens deserve.

Their struggle should spur us to intensify the energetic efforts that are already under way to improve the design of health systems and the delivery of treatment in India. The nation should focus on providing preventive and promotive medicine, which can help people avoid illnesses before they occur; on delivering